

Key findings

1. The twelve models of induction cookers took less time in heating up a reference food item (water), taking a minimum 2.58 minutes to a maximum 4.04 minutes, whereas an LPG stove takes about 5.36 minutes to boil the same quantity of water.

2. With regard to operating cost, the power consumed by induction cookers was between 1501 watts and 2126 watts. Since Westinghouse cooker turned out to be energy-efficient and smart, it was taken as a reference to arrive at the economical operation estimate in electricity and LPG.

3. Inalsa cooker topped in overall performance, followed by Kenwood and Bajaj. Westinghouse cooker was quite energy-efficient and cheaper to operate in the long run, followed by Inalsa—as against Glen and Usha, which cost Rs 605 extra annually.

4. In value for money, Inalsa and Bajaj were rated as good buys, costing Rs 2550 and Rs 2700 as purchase price, respectively.

5. All the cookers performed quite satisfactorily and users can be rest assured about the cooking results, provided the right types of utensils are used as recommended.

6. Results of the cooking tests were quite satisfactory—uniform cooking was found with all the cookers.

7. Westinghouse (Rs 295), Inalsa (Rs 187), Prestige (Rs 100) and Sunflame cookers (Rs 68) were cheaper to operate in a year on electricity than LPG stoves. The remaining eight cookers were more expensive than LPG stoves, costing up to Rs 310 on nominal usage. Glen and Usha cookers were the most expensive to operate, costing additionally about Rs 310 each on a yearly basis.

Interesting facts

Apart from performance metrics of induction cookers, several interesting facts that give this appliance an edge were also highlighted.

Safe. There were no hotspots on the heating surface plate (made of toughened glass/ceramic) of any of the tested induction cookers, making them the safest cooking appliance. The cooking top stays cool as there are no open flames. Also, unlike LPG stoves, there is no gas leakage. So cooking is safer, with very low risk of catching fire or burning one's hands or fingers. Gas stoves release nitrogen oxide resulting in inferior air quality while cooking. On the other hand, the heat in induction cookers does not react with atmospheric gases.

Economical. This aspect becomes evident if the average cooking time and electricity consumption are measured and compared with existing LPG prices. Thermal efficiency of induction cookers is 84 per cent as against minimum 66 per cent of gas stoves. Induction cookers consume half the amount of electricity consumed by traditional electric heaters.

Smokeless. There was no oil burning and no smoke coming out of the oil while deep frying. Hence the surroundings remained clean and the oil left no stain either.

Oil quality. The quality of the oil remained good even after repeated deep frying, and it could easily be reused.

Availability. Induction cooker is a one-time investment and is dependent mainly on power supply—unlike gas stoves, wherein the cylinder had to be refilled at regular intervals. With the new law that translates into rationing on LPG cylinders per household, the induction cooker is a practical alternative.

The only hitch was claims on the wattage and then disparities in ampere capacity of power plugs and the length of power cord. Some cookers claimed lower wattage than actual usage, while others had overrated their wattage.

In overall performance, Inalsa cooker came on top followed by Kenwood and Bajaj. In terms of value for

money, Inalsa and Bajaj topped as these were better performers costing Rs 2550 and Rs 2700, respectively. Westinghouse cooker was quite energy-efficient and cheap to operate among all the cookers tested. ●

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